routes, it does not follow that all routes are equally good or authentic. Since all men are not at the same place, it follows that there is no single route for all men. There must be one shortest route and, therefore, the authentic one. There is a shortest route for everyone, but it is not the same route for all. Men are not equally endowed by nature in their gifts of reason, feeling, and capacity to act, and, therefore, it is not necessary to force men to follow any single path of knowledge, emotion, or action. Attainment of the ultimate goal of life is like a process of education. There is a shortest and an authentic way to be educated, but it is not the same in content for everyone. All men need not be required to excel in the same sphere. Rather, as in education, we encourage a person to follow his or her natural inclinations and talents which he or she happens to be endowed with, the same is true with regard to our religious training also. Does it mean, therefore, that all the ways that a man can take are the paths toward God-realization? The answer is both yes and no. It is "yes" because all men are bound to fulfill their ultimate destiny sooner or later, and "no" because for each one, a particular path will be shorter than another. While the ethical requirements will be the same and identical for all of us, within this moral objectivity and oneness, all men can take to their own and individual paths of finding their fulfillment through any of the three paths: knowledge, devotion, or action. Hinduism has therefore equally recognized the greatness of not only those men who like Gandhi have been great in the world of action, but also those who like Paramhansa Ramakrishna have spent their lives in pure devotion to God, or those who like Śankara or Aurobindo Ghose have been great philosophers. Though there have been and still are great debates and disputes among philosophers about the claims of each of these *Mārgas* for relative supremacy, the prophets of all the three paths have flourished in India with equal claims on the minds of the present-day Hindus, showing once again the great genius of the people in asserting their faith in the doctrine of an essential unity in the midst of diversity and differences.

The Four Āśramas

No account of Hinduism as a religious force and as a philosophy can perhaps be considered as complete without an account of the rationale of not only the four *Puruśārthas,* or the goals of life *(Dharma, Artha, Kāma,* and *Moksa),* but also of the four *Āśramas,* or the stages of an individual's life, and the fourfold *Varna* classification of human society, called the *Varna-āśramas.* We are